pointing out that the ‘alien’ (*paradesi*) company had not restored its old rates but continued with the cut-throat, competitive rates. Was this not, he argued, because it feared that the Swadeshi steamers would start sailing soon and their own ships would have to run empty? He further assured readers that S.D. Krishna Aiyangar and K.R. Venkatarama Aiyar were working hard to clear outstanding dues. Somewhat disingenuously, he even claimed that all dues were ‘more or less settled’.[5] A *Hindu* correspondent, for his part, praised the above two for their ‘great self-sacrifice’ and ‘indefatigable energy’.[6]

Government sources give a different picture. Two reports from the beginning of the year—the first, the DSP’s report from Tirunelveli and the other, a report of the collector of Madurai on an informal visit to Colombo (referred to in the last chapter)—paint a detailed if dismal scenario.

P.B. Thomas, the DSP, reported that, in the first weeks of 1909, some directors of SSNCo met and decided to make one more effort to raise capital. Details of this meeting in January 1909 also emerge from the report presented by nine directors later in the year on 15 August. According to it, ‘an informal conference of some of the principal persons connected with or interested in the company’ took place. Based on what they described as ‘a careful calculation’, they contemplated a scheme which would generate an annual net income of Rs 78,000. This forecast was sent as ‘a private circular letter’ to ‘several leading men in this Presidency’, and there was a positive response to the accompanying appeal.[7] No details of this scheme can be traced, and in any case, nothing came of it.

But Thomas’ report presented a more depressing picture. Apparently, two drastic proposals were considered: selling the *Gallia* and restricting the *Lawoe* only to the coast, abandoning the Tuticorin–Colombo route altogether. Thomas thought it would be difficult to dispose of the *Gallia*—it could only be broken up—while the *Lawoe* would have to be docked and undergo extensive repairs to make it seaworthy. However, the *Lawoe* had been attached on a civil decree against unpaid crew’s wages. There was no business in Tuticorin itself; the *Miranda* was laid up, and the company’s office virtually closed with the clerks having been paid off. The company,